Kennedy met the commander of the US Tactical Air Command, General Walter Sweeney, along with DCI McCone, Secretary McNamara, General Taylor, and Robert Kennedy.[43] Sweeney was confident that an attack would be successful, although Taylor and McNamara cautioned that it was probable only 90% of known missiles would be destroyed. Taylor recommended an air strike the following day and without any warning. As General Turgidson might have added, there was ‘a damn good chance of catching them with their pants down’.

Until the presidential recording became available, there were no indications that Kennedy had initially favoured a military attack on the missiles. At the meeting of the National Security Council on 22 October the President said

> I don’t think we ought to discuss [that we considered an air attack or invasion] under any conditions. We may simply have to do it. In any case, we don’t want to look like we were considering it. So I think we ought to just scratch that from all our statements and conversations, and not ever indicate that that was a course of action open to us. I can’t say that strongly enough. We don’t want to ever have it around that this was one of the alternatives that we considered this week.[44]

Lies, of course, are perpetrated by omission as well as commission.

Kennedy’s concerns were not simply governed by his image in the history books. They focussed on the presentation of his government’s position to US and world opinion. Yet, it is striking how subsequent accounts of the various witnesses to history duly obliged in the forgery of history. The most egregious (and self-serving) subversion of history was provided by Robert Kennedy. While alluding to the argument in favour of force (which he attributed to Dean Acheson), he claimed he led the case against surprise attack:

> Whatever military reasons he [Acheson] and others could marshal, they were nevertheless, in the last analysis, advocating a surprise attack by a very large nation against a very small one.